

FEATURE RICH CELLPHONES & SMARTPHONES

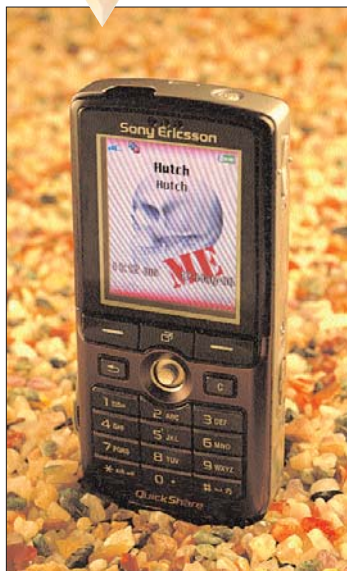
The cell phones in this category ranged from Rs 10,000 to 22,000, a very large range price-wise, but nonetheless, comparable in terms of features. These phones represented the high-and upper-mid-end products that all manufacturers across the board provided us with. The cell phones we received in this category were perhaps the most diverse, in terms of looks, functionality, and definitely, price. In all fairness, it's impossible to compare a Rs 10,000 phone with something that costs over Rs 20,000—regardless of whether they fall into the same category or not. In order to be objective, we've divided these phones into three categories, based on the assumption that India is a very price conscious market. Moreover, each phone has to justify its price.

Rs 10,000 to Rs 12,000

In the Feature Rich category the first mini battle takes place between the Nokia 6600, 7360, and Motorola E398. The Nokia 7360 is the lightest of the three, and is part of Nokia's *L'Amour*—phones that women would want to flaunt. The phone looks snazzy, but we were surprised that it didn't offer Bluetooth connectivity (wireless connectivity includes IR only).

The Motorola E398 impressed us with its build quality—very solid! This is a no frills phone that supports Bluetooth, as well as expandability via a Transflash card—Transflash is advanta-

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The Sony-Ericsson K750i—Small Wonder

geous as it has a very small form factor along with fast transfer rates.

The last phone in this group was Nokia's 6600, an ageing model, albeit one of Nokia's best-selling models of yesteryear. The 6600 shows lack of sharpness in its display, which isn't too noticeable at first, but becomes more pronounced as one compares it to some of the newer models. Although spec-wise the screen is a 65K colour, with a 176 x 208 resolution—identical to most Nokia's—the difference is definitely noticeable.

Another point against the 6600 is its keypad, which is hard when compared to the newer crop of cell phones. The E398 also has a keypad that lacks feedback, something to note for SMS junkies, who want to do a lot of typing. The 6600 does manage to hold its own when it comes to functionality, this is a fully functional Symbian Series 60 smartphone, and can hold its own as far as PIM functions go. The menu layout is more intuitive and easy to navigate than the other two models.

As far as camera quality goes, with VGA class cameras that offer a pixel resolution of 640 x 480, these cameras were never going to be anything great. The E398 and the 6600 were the losers here, with a slight lead in image quality going to the newer 7360. All in all, the image and video quality across all the models wasn't worth much fanfare, with the video playback getting distorted and blurry at times.

How We Tested

The Segregation

One of the most subjective tests of them all, testing cell phones is never easy. Specifications can be noted down, but there are just so many impressions, so many facets of a cell phone that cannot be numerically represented. We received 47 cell phones for testing. These ranged from the very basic phones to the high-end PDA's, with prices ranging from Rs 2,500 to Rs 60,000. Now that is a very large price band, which is impossible to compare head-to-head.

To start off, we divided the cell phones into 5 categories, based on price and features. First, we classified the basic and mid-end phones into two different groups, with the basic group consisting of phones up to Rs 5,500. The mid-end phones were those that cost between Rs 6,000 and Rs 10,000. These categories were considered budget categories, and the weightage was on basic features and functionality here.

The phones that cost between Rs 10,000 and Rs 22,000 were considered the feature-rich and multimedia cell phones, these were awarded points for expansion, multimedia playback, presence of a camera and its quality, as well as the functionality. In case some phones lacked basic features, we were more severe with our point deductions—after all, a costly phone should have all the features of a cheaper model, and more.

The phones that fell under the Lifestyle category weren't pitted against each other, because of the fact that people who buy such phones are looking to make a fashion statement, and such tastes are very personalised. The phones that made it into this category, did so because of their sheer flaunt value.

The Business category was made up of five phones that offered PDA-like functionality, such as the ability to create and edit office documents (Word, Excel, PowerPoint) and PDF files.

The Process

We tested all the phones for their ergonomics and ease of use, if there were any quirks—such as a hard keypad, un-intuitive menu structures, etc.—were noted down, and points were deducted. Even finer nuances, such as the body structure, build quality, keypad backlighting, etc., was all taken into account. The actual phones were tested for menu layout, and ease of use of the features present, besides the usual signal quality and integrity tests, which were carried out simply by dialing the mobile from a landline number, the mobile was carried around to places of weak reception and the voice quality was judged and points awarded. The final score was the aggregate of the max and min signal areas.

The feature-rich category was also tested specifically for camera quality, multimedia playback quality, screen quality, as well as additional functions such as ability to work with office documents. These phones were also awarded points for the expandability they provided. The usual gamut of signal reception tests were also carried out.

The Lifestyle series were also put through the same rigorous testing procedures as the others, but they weren't pitted against each other. Any peculiarities were however noted, and in case of any essential functionality found lacking, this was included in the article.

Finally the PDA/business category of phones, these were tested for office productivity and connectivity like Wi-Fi, the regular multimedia tests done on the feature rich phones wasn't carried out on this category simply because the target audience for such phones will not be likely to go on a photo clicking spree. However music and video playback was tested, as well as the usual call and voice clarity tests.